

Ursus maritimus

Polar bear



Length 6–9 ft (1.8–2.8 m)
Tail 2¼–5 in (6–13 cm)
Weight 331–1,433 lb (150–650 kg)
Location Arctic, N. Canada
Social unit Individual
Status Vulnerable



Vying with the brown bear as the largest land-based carnivore, the male polar bear can weigh twice as much as a female. Its favored habitat is a mix of pack ice, shoreline, and open water where seals are found. Some

bears move 60 miles (100 km) inland in summer and vary their diet with birds' eggs, lemmings, lichens, mosses, and carrion, such as caribou and musk-oxen. Mating occurs on sea ice in April–May. The pregnant female digs a den in snow or earth and gives birth to 2 cubs (range 1–4) from November to January. The cubs take solid food at 5 months but are not weaned for another 2–3 years.

PAW PADDLES

Polar bears swim readily across open water at up to 6 mph (10 kph). They paddle with the massive forepaws—the rear legs trailing as rudders. The coat's hollow, air-filled guard hairs (see also below) aid buoyancy. When diving, the eyes remain open but the nostrils close as the bear holds its breath for up to 2 minutes, coming up stealthily beneath prey such as seabirds or surface-basking seals.



NOT QUITE WHITE
The polar bear's guard (outer) fur is creamy rather than pure white. Hollow and translucent, the guard hairs transmit the sun's heat internally down to their bases, where it is absorbed by the black skin. The dense underfur and thick blubber (fatty layer) under the skin aid insulation.

partially furred paw pads retain heat

STALK OR STILL HUNT

The polar bear's chief prey is seals, which are caught by 2 main hunting methods. In the stalk, the polar bear moves slowly nearer its prey, relying on its camouflaging white coat and "freezing" if the seal looks up. It then charges the last 50–100 ft (15–30 m) at up to 34 mph (55 kph). In the still hunt, the bear waits motionless on the ice next to a seal's breathing hole, and grabs the prey as it surfaces. The bear bites the seal's head and drags it a short distance for consumption.



straight profile
longer neck than other bears

Ursus americanus

American black bear



Length 4–6¼ ft (1.2–1.9 m)
Tail Up to 4¾ in (12 cm)
Weight 88–496 lb (40–225 kg)
Location North America, Mexico
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



The American black bear is adaptable in habitat, but generally prefers forested country. Its powerful limbs and short claws tear open old logs to search for worms and grubs, and are also excellent for tree climbing, when this bear plucks fruit with its prehensile lips. The ears are larger and more erect than those of the brown bear, and it lacks a prominent shoulder hump. It sleeps in winter, which lasts up to 6 months in the north of its range. This bear may break into outbuildings or vehicles to obtain food left by humans, but it usually flees on confrontation.

MAINLY VEGETARIAN



Some 95 percent of this bear's diet is plant-based, including, according to season, roots, buds, shoots, fruit, berries, and nuts, which are often obtained by climbing. It may also become adept at hunting deer fawns and at catching fish.



BLACK TO BLUE BEARS
In the east, black is the main fur color, but in the west, it may be cinnamon or yellow-brown, and on the Pacific coast, gray-blue.

Ursus thibetanus

Asiatic black bear

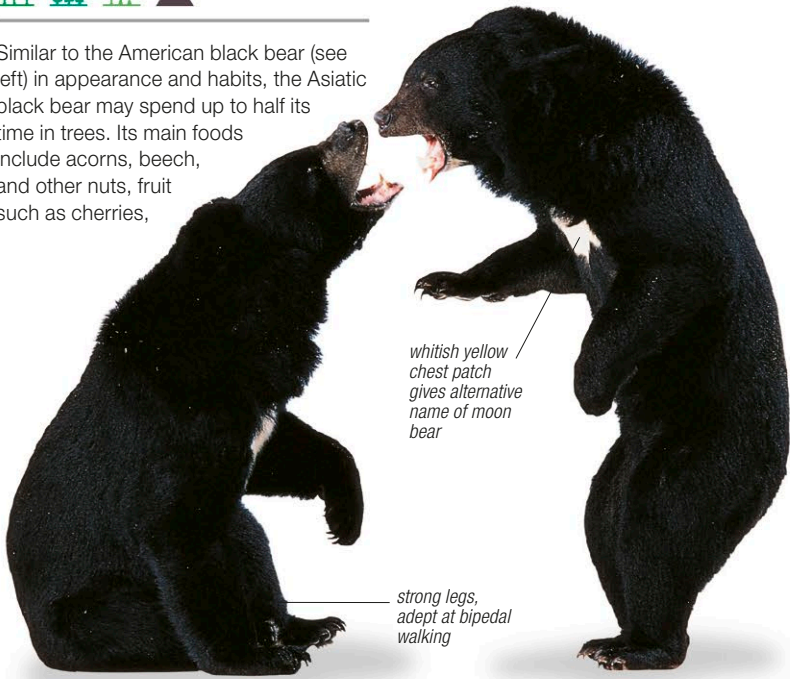


Length 3½–6¼ ft (1.1–1.9 m)
Tail Up to 4¾ in (12 cm)
Weight 77–441 lb (35–200 kg)
Location E., S., and S.E. Asia
Social unit Individual
Status Vulnerable



bamboo shoots and leaves, grasses, herbs, grubs, and insects such as ants. Where its natural forest habitat has been farmed and become fragmented, this bear may raid corn and other crops and, on occasions, has caused human fatalities. Eight months after mating the female gives birth in her winter den to 1–3 (usually 2) cubs. The Asiatic black bear is hunted for its body parts (especially the gall bladder), which are used in Asian cuisine and medicines.

Similar to the American black bear (see left) in appearance and habits, the Asiatic black bear may spend up to half its time in trees. Its main foods include acorns, beech, and other nuts, fruit such as cherries,



whitish yellow chest patch gives alternative name of moon bear

strong legs, adept at bipedal walking